

RAGHAV KHANNA

Nurturer of Wholesome Vitality

IN ALL OF MODERN CULTURE, PERHAPS NO PHASE OF LIFE IS as romanticised as one's (uni)varsity years. And if those years are spent amid the lush greenery of the Western Ghats, with monsoon rains turning gentle crevices into meandering rivulets, it's an experience that could inspire a Coleridge. For many professionals across various industries—be it pharmaceuticals, telecommunications, marketing, or entertainment—this was their reality for two transformative years. Symbiosis, or Symbi, as it's colloquially known, is more than just a university or a shared campus; it's a shared life.



SYMBIOTIC GROWTH Students at a study session in a library at SIU

MANDAR DEODHAR

Years after graduating, alumni still recognise each other with a nod of familiarity, having eaten the same campus food, ridden the same bicycles from hostel to classroom, taken the same buses to the city, and missing the same buses back to the campus. Personally, my time at Symbiosis was a period when an abundance of time coincided, almost perfectly, with a deep sense of purpose. Before this, while time was plentiful, purpose was mostly a distant dream. Later, when purpose became a bold, highlighted, underlined goal, screaming to me—in all caps—every morning, time became a scarce commodity. The most valued elements of professional life—time, space, friendships and guidance—were nurtured during my years at Symbiosis. Reflecting back, more than a decade since leaving the Symbiosis Institute of Media and Communication (SIMC) at Symbiosis International (Deemed University) in Pune, these years remain the most memorable and formative of my journey.

The luxury to watch four films a day, attend two-hour seminars on film appreciation, or have midnight chats with fellow film enthusiasts is something I cherish from my time at SIMC. What truly enriched my learning experience at SIMC was the ease of access to resources like cameras, editing machines, expansive screening theatres, and, most importantly, a dedicated crew of peers, willing to give their all to realise our vision— essential for any filmmaker. Guest lectures from industry professionals added real-world insights that awaited us all.

As a recluse or, at best, an ambivert, I formed lifelong associations that have enriched my professional journey. Symbiosis is not just a network but a deeply entrenched community, even a family, for many of us. Over the years, my fondness for this time has only grown, nurturing me in ways that have shaped who I am today. ■

The author is a writer, director and producer. He graduated from Symbiosis Institute of Media and Communication in 2011 with an MA in audio-visual production